



Brand Guidelines

Version 2.0 | April 2026

Brand essence

The Marblehead Independent is a community-powered local news outlet devoted exclusively to Marblehead, Massachusetts. It is produced by a team of columnists, writers and photographers united by a commitment to clear, trustworthy, independent reporting on local government, schools, public life and culture. Its identity is rooted in civic service, clarity and editorial seriousness — with personality.

Name usage

- Always refer to the publication as The Marblehead Independent on first reference.
- Do not italicize the name.
- On subsequent references, three informal nicknames are acceptable: the Indy, the Independent and MHD Indy. These have become part of the publication’s vernacular with readers and may be used in casual or conversational contexts — social posts, newsletter copy, reader correspondence and internal shorthand. MHD Indy is also the handle root across social platforms.
- Do not abbreviate the name as “TMI” or any other acronym.
- Example first reference: “According to The Marblehead Independent...”
- Example subsequent reference: “The Indy reported last week that...”

Tagline

Primary tagline:

Independent journalism for Marblehead. No paywall. Reader supported.

This line may be used on the homepage banner, in the newsletter header, in social bios and on sponsor-facing materials. It is the publication’s public promise and should appear in Georgia wherever possible.

The logo

The logo of The Marblehead Independent is a hand-carved, hand-printed linocut illustration of the Old Town House, the 1727 colonial meetinghouse on Market Square that has served as Marblehead’s civic heart for nearly three centuries. The illustration was cut from a single linoleum block and printed by hand, then colored to reflect the building’s ochre clapboards, stone foundation, green paneled door and the American flag flying from its cupola.

The choice of medium is deliberate. A linocut is the work of one pair of hands — carved, inked, pressed and colored without mechanical reproduction. It is an image that could not have been generated or assembled; it had to be made. That quality mirrors the spirit of the publication itself: a newsroom built by hand, line by

line, for a single community.

The building it depicts is equally intentional. The Old Town House is where Marblehead has gathered to govern itself, to argue, to vote and to decide since before the American Revolution. It is not a scenic landmark or a waterfront postcard. It is the place where the town does its work. As the home of local self-governance, it represents exactly what The Marblehead Independent exists to cover: the civic life of Marblehead.

Details of the illustration:

The Old Town House is rendered in its recognizable form — the steep gable, the decorative rosette window in the peak, eight windows with white trim, the pedimented entrance bearing the date 1727, a stone-and-mortar foundation and front steps ascending to the green door. The cupola rises from the roofline and flies the American flag. The building is colored in warm ochre and gold, outlined in dark ink, on a Shell White ground.

The nameplate

The nameplate is the horizontal lockup used in the site header and newsletter masthead. It pairs the Old Town House linocut on the left with the publication name to the right. “The Marblehead” is set in Georgia at display scale in Harbor Black. “INDEPENDENT” sits directly below in bold, all caps, in Independent Red. The two words share a baseline rhythm that gives the nameplate the proportional weight and seriousness of a traditional newspaper flag.

The nameplate should always appear on Shell White or a very light background. It should not be placed over photographs, dark fields or busy textures. The linocut illustration and the type are a single composed unit; do not separate, rearrange or independently resize the elements.

Stacked logo variant:

A stacked version exists for square or vertical formats — social avatars, favicons and other constrained spaces. In this layout the Old Town House illustration sits above the type, centered. The same typographic rules apply.

Color palette

Primary colors:



Independent Red — #C2261D

Use for INDEPENDENT in the logo and for high-impact elements such as CTAs and tags.

**Harbor Black — #1E1F21**

Default text and headline color. Serious, legible and classic.

**Shell White — #FDF9F4**

Site background. Clean, soft and warm — avoids harsh contrast.

Optional accent:**Slate Blue — #375E97**

For hyperlinks, light accent elements or muted highlights. Avoid overuse.

All colors should support the typographic-first feel of the site. When in doubt, keep it black and white.

Typography

Primary typeface: Georgia

- Used for all headlines, subheads, body text and editorial content.
- Classic, literary and highly readable on screen and in print.
- Georgia is the voice of The Marblehead Independent. It should never be replaced or overridden for editorial content.

Optional secondary typeface: Inter (or Open Sans)

- Use only for navigation menus, buttons or system UI elements where a sans-serif improves usability.
- Should not compete with Georgia in tone or visual weight.

Logo usage rules

Primary logo:

- “The Marblehead” in Georgia, serif, title case.
- “INDEPENDENT” in all caps, bold, Independent Red.
- Always center or left-align depending on layout.
- Use only on Shell White or very light backgrounds.

Do not:

- Stretch, distort or recolor the logo or illustration.

- Replace the fonts or lowercase “INDEPENDENT.”
- Apply shadows, gradients or other graphic effects.
- Separate the illustration from the type.
- Use on dark, photographic or cluttered backgrounds.
- Reproduce the linocut illustration without the accompanying type except in the stacked logo variant.

Editorial voice

- Direct but never stiff.
- Personal but never casual.
- Civic but never bureaucratic.
- Plainspoken, truth-first, local in tone.

Think: CBS Sunday Morning meets 60 Minutes — the warmth and texture of one, the accountability and seriousness of the other.

Tone by content type

The editorial voice adapts across the Indy’s content categories while staying rooted in the same character.

News. Straight, factual, concise. Let the reporting do the work. No editorializing in news copy. Attribution is precise and sourcing is transparent.

Features. Warmer, more narrative. Room for scene-setting, character and texture. This is the CBS Sunday Morning side of the voice — unhurried, human, richly observed.

Opinion and letters to the editor. Reader submissions are published under the “To the editor:” header, which uses the stacked Old Town House illustration with “To the editor:” set in Independent Red beneath it on a Shell White field. Letters are lightly edited for clarity and length but the writer’s voice is preserved. The Indy does not publish anonymous letters. All opinion content is clearly labeled and separated from news reporting.

From the Editor’s Desk. The editor’s column. First person, conversational, direct address to the reader. This is where the Indy’s personality is most visible — reflective, occasionally funny, always grounded in Marblehead.

Police Log. Dry, factual, lightly wry. The police log uses the series label format — “POLICE LOG:” in all caps followed by a descriptive headline. The tone acknowledges the often absurd nature of small-town police blotter entries without mocking anyone involved.

Recurring columns. Series like “Colleen’s Garden” carry their own byline and voice. The series label appears in all caps as a tag and in the headline format “SERIES NAME: Headline.” Contributors maintain their own style within the Indy’s general editorial standards.

Headline and series formatting

Headlines follow AP style: capitalize only the first word and proper nouns. Headlines should be clear and descriptive, not clever at the expense of clarity.

Recurring series use a consistent format: the series name in all caps, followed by a colon and the specific headline. Examples: “COLLEEN’S GARDEN: April in the garden,” “POLICE LOG: Alleged cartel caller settles for \$500, skis vanish from snowbank and cruiser loses a battle with its own wiper blade,” “FROM THE EDITOR’S DESK: The story behind the Independent’s new nameplate.”

New recurring series should be established only when there is a clear editorial commitment to ongoing coverage. Each series should have a distinct, short label that works in all caps.

Byline format

Bylines appear below the headline in small caps: the author’s name, followed by the publication date. The format is consistent across all content types. Contributors and guest columnists receive the same byline treatment as the editor.

Corrections policy

Accuracy is the Indy’s most important asset. When an error is identified in a published story, a correction is placed at the top of the article, clearly labeled. Corrections should state what was wrong and what is correct. They should not be buried in the text or appended as a footnote.

The format is:

“Correction: [Date] — An earlier version of this article [describe the error]. [State the accurate information].”

The original article text is updated to reflect the correction. Corrections are not removed once posted.

Letters and reader submissions

The Indy welcomes letters to the editor and reader-submitted tips, photos and story ideas through the Submit page at /submissions.

Letters to the editor are published under the “To the editor:” header graphic, which pairs the stacked Old Town House illustration with the phrase “To the editor:” in Independent Red. Letters are edited for length and clarity but not for substance or opinion. The Indy does not publish anonymous letters; all letters carry the writer’s name and town of residence. The editor reserves the right to decline letters that contain personal attacks, unverifiable claims or content that does not meet the publication’s editorial standards.

Reader photos and tips may be used in reporting with attribution. Submitting a photo or tip does not guarantee publication.

Mission and values references

The Marblehead Independent maintains two public-facing documents that articulate its editorial mission and principles:

The Indy Promise (marbleheadindependent.com/the-indy-promise) — the publication’s commitment to readers regarding what they can expect from the Indy’s coverage and conduct.

The Independent’s North Stars (marbleheadindependent.com/the-independents-north-stars) — the guiding principles that shape editorial decisions and priorities.

Editorial Standards (marbleheadindependent.com/editorial-standards) and the **Editorial Independence & Sponsorship Policy** (marbleheadindependent.com/editorial-independence-sponsorship-policy) are also published on the site and linked in the footer.

These documents are part of the Indy’s public identity and should be referenced in any press kit, sponsor packet or about page.

Editorial standards

A house style guide specific to The Marblehead Independent is in development. Until that guide is complete, all published content defaults to Associated Press style. Key conventions include: capitalize only the first word and proper nouns in headlines; spell out numbers zero through nine and use numerals for 10 and above; do not use the serial comma; use a.m. and p.m. with periods and lowercase; abbreviate months of more than five letters when paired with a specific date; and use “noon” and “midnight” rather than 12 p.m. or 12 a.m.

All sources should be clearly attributed. Direct quotes must preserve exact wording. Use full name on first reference, last name only on subsequent references. Do not use courtesy titles (Mr., Mrs., Ms.) except in direct quotations.

Social media

Handles:

- X (Twitter): @mhdindy
- Instagram: @mhdindy
- Bluesky: @mhdindy.bsky.social
- Facebook: The Marblehead Independent

Voice and usage:

Social posts should reflect the same editorial tone as the site — plainspoken, local, direct. Use the stacked logo variant as the profile avatar across all platforms. Link back to articles on the site whenever possible. Do not editorialize in social headlines beyond what appears in the published story.

Site structure

The website navigation reflects the publication’s editorial priorities and should remain clean and limited. Current sections:

- **News** — the primary reporting section covering local government, schools and public affairs.
- **Features** — longer-form stories, profiles and cultural coverage.
- **Opinion** — letters to the editor, guest columns and editorial content.
- **Archive** — the newsletter archive.
- **Submit** — reader submissions, tips and letters.
- **About** — the publication’s mission, story and founding principles.
- **Sponsors** — the sponsor acknowledgment page.
- **Founders’ Circle** — recognition of founding supporters.

The homepage includes an announcement bar at the top with the primary tagline and a link to the free newsletter signup. The header button in the upper right reads “WAYS TO SUPPORT” and links to /ways-to-support.

Newsletter identity

Name:

The weekly letter from The Marblehead Independent

Layout guidance:

- Use the full nameplate or stacked logo in the header.
- Single column, minimalist layout.
- All text in Georgia.
- Include sections such as a welcome or editor’s note, a top story highlight, a sponsor acknowledgment and an optional civic calendar or reader spotlight.

Sponsors page guidelines

URL: /sponsors

This page should include:

1. A brief intro stating that the publication's work is made possible by local sponsors who believe in independent journalism.
2. A logo grid or simple name list of current sponsors.
3. A short section explaining why businesses should sponsor the Independent.
4. A clear call-to-action with an email address or Stripe link.
5. Optional sponsor testimonials.

Do not include donations, volunteer opportunities or reader contributions on this page. Keep it exclusively about sponsorship.

Photography and image guidelines

Images on the site should feel documentary and authentic — never staged, stock or overly processed. Preferred sources are original photography, public records and reader submissions. Captions should always include attribution and context. All images should be legible against the Shell White background.

When featuring the linocut illustration outside the nameplate — in merchandise, print materials or promotional graphics — use the standalone illustration file on Shell White with adequate clear space around it. Do not crop into the illustration or overlay text on top of it.

Favicon and Open Graph image

The browser favicon uses the Old Town House illustration without accompanying type, scaled to fit standard favicon dimensions.

The default Open Graph image — the preview that appears when an Indy link is shared on social media or in messaging apps — is the stacked logo variant: the Old Town House illustration centered above “The Marblehead” and “INDEPENDENT” on a Shell White field. Individual articles should generate their own Open Graph images using the article's featured photo when one is available.

Email signature

A standard email signature should be used for all editorial and sponsor correspondence:

Will Dowd
Editor, The Marblehead Independent
marbleheadindependent.com
@mhdindy

The signature should be set in a clean, readable font. Do not include the linocut illustration in email signatures, as image rendering is unreliable across email clients.

Co-branding with sponsors

When the Indy's brand appears alongside a sponsor's logo — in a newsletter, on a shared flyer, at an event or in a digital ad — the following rules apply:

- The Indy's nameplate or stacked logo should appear at its full size and never be reduced smaller than the sponsor's mark.
- Maintain clear visual separation between the Indy's brand and the sponsor's brand. Do not blend logos, share a background color field or merge the two identities.
- Sponsor acknowledgments should use the language "Sponsored by" or "Supported by" — not "Presented by" or "In partnership with," which imply editorial collaboration.
- The Indy's editorial independence and sponsorship policy governs all sponsor relationships. No sponsor may influence, review or approve editorial content.

Legal notes

- The Marblehead Independent is operated as a sole proprietorship, legally registered under the business name The Rumpus Room.
- "The Marblehead Independent" is the public-facing name used on the website, newsletter and all sponsor-facing materials.
- The business is not a nonprofit but operates with a nonprofit-style mission and funding model.
- Stripe is the authorized payment processor. All funds received under the Independent name are linked to the business bank account.